

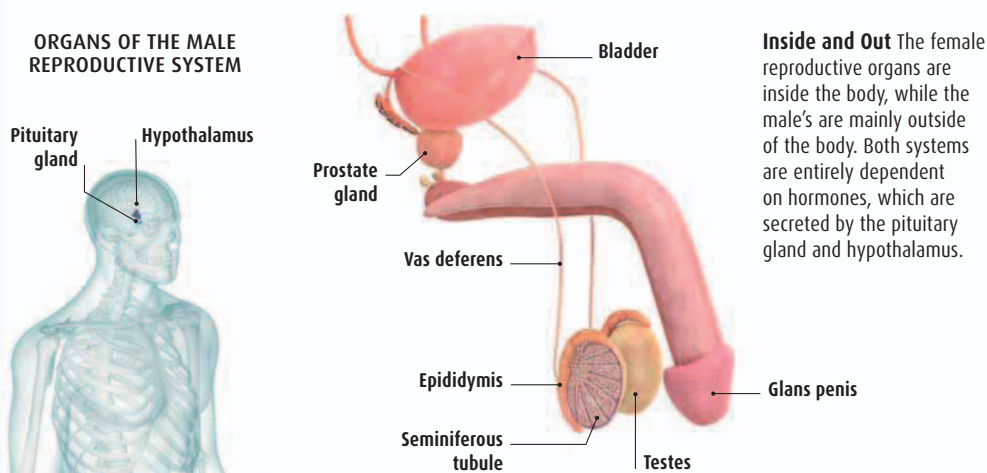
Q What will happen inside my body when I conceive?

Becoming pregnant is a complex biological process. First, it requires the release of an egg from the ovary. This egg must then be fertilized by a sperm in the fallopian tube. Once fertilized, the egg becomes a ball of cells that must travel down the fallopian tube and implant in the lining of the uterus. When this occurs, you have conceived and are pregnant.

Creating new life

You will have the best chance of conceiving if your reproductive organs are healthy and functioning well. Sperm are produced in a man's testes. Once matured in the epididymis, the sperm travel into a tube, the vas deferens, which leads to a sac like structure. When a man ejaculates, semen—a fluid containing the sperm—discharges into the urethra inside the penis. In a woman, the ovaries are positioned on either side of the uterus. They contain the eggs, or ova, that are released each month (ovulation).

ORGANS OF THE MALE REPRODUCTIVE SYSTEM



The egg's journey

All the eggs in an ovary are exposed to follicle-stimulating hormone (FSH) each month in order to mature, but only about 20 develop. Eggs mature within follicles, fluid-filled structures that enlarge in response to FSH. Usually only one follicle matures fully and releases an egg, while the other follicles shrivel and their eggs are lost.

If a woman has a nonidentical twin pregnancy, it means two of her follicles have matured and each one released an egg that month.

Ovulation triggers

The mature egg is surrounded by cells that produce the hormone estrogen. This stimulates the growth of tissue in the breasts, thickens the uterine lining, and nourishes the egg. As the levels of estrogen rise, the hypothalamus in the brain triggers a burst of luteinizing hormone (LH) that works to release the egg from its follicle: ovulation occurs.

The fallopian tube

At the point of ovulation, the newly released egg is wafted into the nearby fallopian tube by delicate frondlike strands called fimbriae. It is encouraged down the tube toward the uterus by tiny hairlike projections, known as cilia, in the lining. This can take five days or more. If a woman has sexual intercourse around this time, the egg may be fertilized by a sperm while it is in the fallopian tube.

